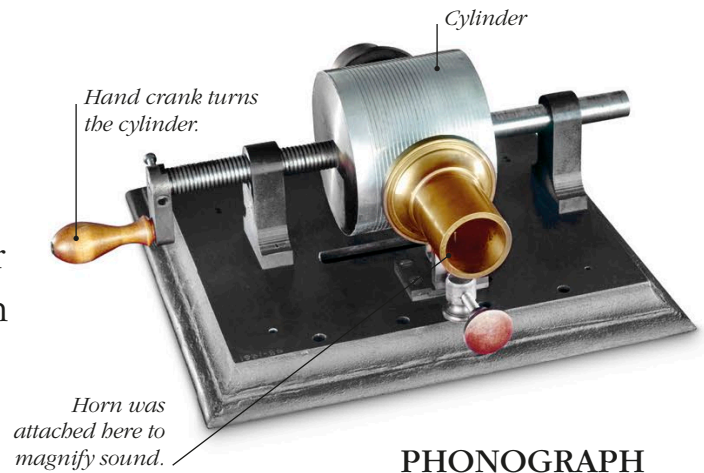


Recorded music

Until the late 19th century, the only way to hear music was to listen to it live. Then the invention of the telephone in 1876 showed that sound could be transmitted electrically. This spurred the American inventor Thomas Edison (see pp.186–187) to explore if it was possible to record sound. His invention, the phonograph, kick-started the recorded music industry.

RECORDING WITHOUT ELECTRICITY

For early recordings, musicians played directly into a large horn, causing the sound waves to move the recording needle. The horn gathered only a small amount of sound, producing low-quality recordings. Microphones, invented in the 1870s, improved sound, though not as much as the far more sensitive “ultra audible” microphone that appeared in the 1920s.



PHONOGRAPH

Invented in 1877, Edison's phonograph consisted of a horn, a needle, and a rotating cylinder covered in tin foil. When sound was played into the horn, the needle traced a groove in the foil as the cylinder turned.

To play back the recording, the needle was drawn through the groove again.

Later phonographs used a wax cylinder to make and play recordings (see p.206).

▼ PLAY IT LOUD

Before microphones, musicians gathered in front of one large horn to record.

